

“Walden” by Henry David Thoreau

[B2]

Una vita più semplice, ma felice. Stabilendosi in quella capanna sul lago, Thoreau anticipò le idee centrali dell’ambientalismo e della filosofia della nonviolenza.



In the [early summer](#) of 1845, a twenty-seven-year-old American called Henry David Thoreau built a small cabin in the woods of Massachusetts. He moved into the cabin on 4 July, Independence Day in the United States. The date was not a coincidence. Tired of what he saw as the [lack](#) of spirituality in modern life, Thoreau's cabin was a way of declaring his own independence from the outside world. For the next two years, including two intensely cold winters, the [one-roomed](#) cabin would be his main home. He wrote a book about the time he spent there. Its title, Walden, was inspired by the small lake called Walden [Pond](#) that [lay](#) just outside his front door. Walden is Thoreau's [masterpiece](#), a book that still inspires people around the world to dream of a more meaningful life.

TRANSCENDENTALISM

Growing up in the small city of Concord, Massachusetts, Thoreau was surrounded by some of the most brilliant minds in America. These included the writer Nathaniel Hawthorne, and Thoreau's teacher, the philosopher Ralph Waldo Emerson. Emerson's philosophy, known as Transcendentalism, deeply influenced Thoreau's thinking. One element of Transcendentalism is that an experience with the divine could be [attained](#) through interaction with the natural world. For example, in Walden, Thoreau writes about seeing a specific type of fish in Walden [Pond](#): "I am always surprised by their rare beauty, as if they were fabulous fishes, they are so foreign to the streets, even to the woods, foreign as Arabia to our Concord life. They possess a quite dazzling and transcendent beauty." "[...] sono sempre sorpreso dalla loro rara bellezza, come se fossero pesci favolosi, tanto stranieri essi sono agli abitanti della città e a quelli dei boschi: tanto quanto l'Arabia è straniera alla nostra vita di Concord. Posseggono una bellezza abbagliante e trascendentale [...]"

KEEPING IT SIMPLE

Like Emerson, Thoreau believed that much of modern, industrial life was materialistic and sterile. He thought individuals should try to [avoid](#) conforming to its demands, and find their own place in the universe. "Simplify, simplify [...]. Instead of three meals a day, if it be necessary eat but one; instead of a hundred dishes, five; and reduce other things in proportion." "Semplificate, semplificate! Invece di tre pasti al giorno fatene uno solo, se è necessario; invece di cento piatti, cinque, e riducete tutte le altre cose proporzionalmente." Walden [Pond](#), part of Walden [Pond](#) State Reservation in Massachusetts. The site was designated a National Historic Landmark in 1962 because of its association with Henry David Thoreau.

HEIGHTENED SENSES

Thoreau wanted to live as simply as he could in the cabin and Walden is a description of this experiment. In the book, he notes the positive effects that austerity had on him. If he suffered from hunger or cold, then at least he was experiencing something authentic.

IT'S NATURAL TO BE PRACTICAL

Although a great intellectual, Thoreau [prided himself](#) on his practicality. He describes how he cut down pine trees for the structure of the cabin and built the cabin's chimney from stones he [dug up](#) and carried himself. His days were divided between practical tasks and observing nature. And he emphasised how doing practical tasks should be a natural part of human experience. "There is some of the same fitness in a man's building his own house that there is in a bird's building its own nest. Who knows but if men constructed their dwellings with their own hands, and provided food for themselves and families simply and honestly enough, the poetic faculty would be universally developed, as birds universally sing when they are so engaged?" "Costruendosi la casa, l'uomo rivela la stessa attitudine dell'uccello nel costruirsi il nido. Chissà, se gli uomini si costruissero le loro case con le loro mani e provvedessero il cibo per sé e per le loro famiglie con sufficiente onestà e semplicità, se le loro tendenze poetiche non sarebbero universalmente sviluppate come negli uccelli, che cantano anche quando si stanno costruendo il nido?" Classic Books

"One Flew Over The Cuckoo's Nest" by Ken Kesey Un romanzo toccante, che parla di quanto sia difficile adattarsi a una società che ci vuole "normali" e che cerca di reprimere ogni genere di diversità. Daniel Francis , Rachel Roberts, Sarah Davison

THOSE WHO WENT BEFORE

Like other transcendentalists, Thoreau was horrified by injustice, especially [slavery](#) in the United States. He was also one of the first Americans to recognise the importance of the culture of Native Americans. Walden contains many references to Indigenous customs in the surrounding woods, and Thoreau imagines how Indigenous peoples might have used Walden [Pond](#). As a critic of modern industrial society, Thoreau saw the environmental [threat](#) to the woods of the development of the railway. In Walden, he recognised that technological advances are built by exploiting and abusing poor workers, often immigrants from Ireland: "We do not ride on the railroad; it rides upon us. Did you ever think what lies under the sleepers of the railroad? Each one is a man, an Irishman, or a Yankee man." "Non siamo noi a viaggiare su di essa, è essa che

corre sopra di noi. Avete mai pensato cosa sono quelle traversine che giacciono sotto i binari? Ognuna di esse è un uomo — irlandese o yankee.”

WALDEN’S LEGACY

Thoreau’s writings against [slavery](#) and injustice inspired Gandhi and Martin Luther King Jr., and Walden is [regarded](#) as a foundational text for the modern environmentalist movement. Thoreau’s influence even extends to preoccupations of life in the digital age. The term ‘[brain rot](#)’, now widely used to describe the destructive effects of social media, first appeared in Walden to describe what Thoreau sees as the “fatal” [condition](#) of modern life.

Glossary

- **Pond** = stagno, laghetto
- **avoid** = evitare
- **slavery** = schiavitù
- **brain rot** = marciume mentale
- **condition** = malattia
- **one-roomed** = con una sola stanza
- **masterpiece** = capolavoro
- **threat** = minaccia
- **attained** = raggiungere, ottenere
- **prided himself** = sentirsi orgoglioso
- **early summer** = a inizio estate
- **lack** = mancanza
- **lay** = essere situato
- **dug up** = dissotterrare
- **regarded** = considerare